Name: Somtochukwu Augustus Nwanno

Major: Computer Science

Classification: Junior

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Introduction

Across this course, one theme kept coming back: African-American history is not just a story of suffering, but a long record of creativity, resistance, and organizing against systems that tried to erase Black life. From West African empires to Black Lives Matter, every reading from The American Yawp, the primary-source reader, and the films we watched showed that the African-American experience was shaped by both violence and remarkable determination. In my view, the ten most significant people, events, and movements we studied are: Mansa Musa and the Mali Empire, the Middle Passage, Olaudah Equiano, David Walker, Angelina Grimké, the abolitionist movement, the Harlem Renaissance, the modern civil rights movement, the Rainbow Coalition, and the Black Lives Matter movement. Together, they trace how Black people moved from being captured and exploited to becoming central actors in struggles for freedom in the United States and beyond.

1. Mansa Musa and the Mali Empire

I start with **Mansa Musa**, the 14th-century ruler of the Mali Empire, because he reminds me that African history *before* slavery was powerful, wealthy, and educated. Mansa Musa controlled a huge West African empire built on gold and salt trade, and historians describe him as one of the wealthiest rulers in world history. His famous pilgrimage (hajj) to Mecca in 1324, where he traveled with a huge caravan and gave away so much gold that it affected prices in Cairo, shocked the Mediterranean world and put West Africa on global maps.

In class, learning about him challenged the racist idea that Africa was "backwards" and had no civilization until Europeans arrived. His patronage of learning in Timbuktu, where mosques and universities attracted scholars across the Muslim world, showed that African societies had their own centers of knowledge and culture. For me, that changes the meaning of later slavery: it was not that people were enslaved because they had no history; it was that powerful African societies were violently drawn into the Atlantic system.

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2. The Middle Passage

If Mansa Musa represents African power, the **Middle Passage** represents the violent tearing away of that world. The American Yawp describes how enslaved Africans were forced on a series of journeys: marched to the coast, held in forts, then packed into ships for the "middle leg" of the Atlantic slave trade. Conditions on these ships were horrific; people were chained below deck, lying in their own waste, facing disease, beatings, and constant fear. Many died before even reaching the Americas.

The video "The Middle Passage: A Brutal Slave-Trade Supply Chain" helped me picture what those numbers actually meant in human terms: over twelve million Africans taken, families separated, and

bodies thrown overboard when they got sick. The Middle Passage is significant to me because it shows how slavery was not just about "labor," but about a whole system that treated Black people as cargo in a global supply chain. It's the moment where the African-American story begins with trauma, but also with survival, because millions of people still lived through it and carried their cultures with them.

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3. Olaudah Equiano and the Power of Testimony

Olaudah Equiano is one of the most important individual voices we read. His narrative, printed in the American Yawp Reader, describes being kidnapped as a child, sold multiple times, and enduring the Middle Passage. He talks about the ship as a place of screams, stench, and terror. Reading his own words made the Middle Passage feel less like a distant event and more like listening to someone who actually lived it.

Equiano later bought his freedom and became an abolitionist writer and lecturer in Britain. His story matters for the African-American experience because it shows how enslaved people were not silent objects, they were witnesses who wrote back to the world. Through his narrative, Equiano turned his trauma into political power, convincing readers that slavery was morally wrong. That pattern turning personal experience into public activism runs all the way through African-American history.

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4. David Walker's *Appeal*

In the early 1800s, **David Walker** pushed Black resistance to a new level. The American Yawp describes him as a free Black man in Boston who wrote *Appeal to the Colored Citizens of the World* in 1829, a pamphlet that called out both slavery and northern racism. Walker argued that slavery completely contradicted American ideas of Christianity and the Declaration of Independence.

What stands out to me is how bold and angry the *Appeal* is. Walker did not ask white people politely to change; he warned that God's justice would punish a nation that held people in chains. Southern authorities were so scared of his ideas that they tried to ban the pamphlet and threatened anyone caught distributing it. Walker shows that before the Civil War, Black thinkers were already demanding immediate freedom and equality, not just gradual change or colonization. His voice helped inspire later abolitionists like William Lloyd Garrison.

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5. Angelina Grimké and Moral Suasion

Angelina Grimké represents a different, but connected, form of resistance. A white woman from a slaveholding South Carolina family, she left the South and joined the abolitionist movement. In her pamphlet *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836), which we read through the American Yawp Reader, she urged Southern white women to see slavery as a sin and to act against it. She used "moral suasion", trying to change hearts by appealing to Christian values and the Bible.

The PBS clip on Angelina Grimké helped me see how radical it was for a woman in that era to speak publicly about politics at all, let alone to criticize her own class and family. Grimké is important to African-American history because abolition was never just a Black struggle; some white allies risked everything to join it. She also connects antislavery to early women's rights, reminding me that different justice movements often grow together.

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6. The Abolitionist Movement and William Lloyd Garrison

The **abolitionist movement** of the 1830s–1860s brought many of these voices together into an organized campaign to end slavery. The American Yawp's "Religion and Reform" chapter shows how William

Lloyd Garrison shifted from supporting gradual emancipation and colonization to demanding immediate freedom, influenced by writings from Black abolitionists like Walker. In 1831 he founded the newspaper *The Liberator*, whose opening editorial we read in the Reader. Garrison refused to "think, or speak, or write with moderation" about slavery and insisted it was a national sin.

The documentaries we watched about abolitionists, especially the clips on Garrison and his circle—showed how abolitionists used newspapers, petitions, and lectures to build a mass movement. They were unpopular, even in the North, and often faced mobs and violence. I chose the abolitionist movement as one of my ten because it proves that slavery didn't just "fade away"; people organized for decades to destroy it, and free Black activists were at the center of that struggle.

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7. The Harlem Renaissance and the "New Negro"

Jumping forward to the 1920s, the **Harlem Renaissance** marks a shift from fighting mainly for physical freedom to fighting for cultural and psychological freedom. The American Yawp's chapter on the New Era and the Reader selection from Alain Locke's "Enter the New Negro" describe a generation of Black artists and thinkers who were tired of old stereotypes and wanted "a new vision of opportunity". Harlem became a cultural capital where writers like Langston Hughes and Zora Neale Hurston, musicians like Duke Ellington, and visual artists all experimented with new forms.

Other sources, like the National Museum of African American History and Culture and the Poetry Foundation, describe this period as a "spiritual coming of age" when Black people insisted on defining themselves instead of letting white society define them. I think the Harlem Renaissance is crucial because it shows that resistance is not only protests and laws; it is also poetry, jazz, and painting. It gave later movements a language of pride—"Black is beautiful"—that continues into hip-hop and Black art today.

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8. The Modern Civil Rights Movement

The **Civil Rights Movement** of the 1950s and 1960s is probably the most famous part of African-American history, but this course helped me see its depth. Legally, the story begins with *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954), where the Supreme Court finally overturned "separate but equal" and ruled that segregated schools were unconstitutional. On the ground, ordinary people made that legal decision real: Rosa Parks and the Montgomery Bus Boycott challenged segregation in public transportation, as described in Yawp's chapter on "The Affluent Society."

The videos and images from the Yawp chapter on "The Sixties" reminded me that the movement was not just one march; it was years of sit-ins, Freedom Rides, Birmingham, and finally the Selma-to-Montgomery marches in 1965, where peaceful marchers were beaten on "Bloody Sunday" and later returned in even larger numbers. That pressure helped push through the Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965. I picked this movement because it shows how disciplined, nonviolent mass protest, grounded in Black churches and communities, could change federal law and transform American democracy—even though, as we discussed in class, the struggle did not end there.

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9. The Rainbow Coalition

The **Rainbow Coalition** of the late 1960s, led by Illinois Black Panther Party leader Fred Hampton along with the Young Lords and the Young Patriots, was one of the most eye-opening things we studied. In Chicago, Hampton helped build a multiracial alliance between poor Black, Puerto Rican, and white Appalachian communities to fight police brutality, bad housing, and poverty. This coalition is significant to me for two reasons. First, it shows that Black freedom struggles have always been connected to broader fights against class inequality and state violence. Second, the intense government repression against Hampton and the Panthers, including the FBI's COINTELPRO program and Hampton's assassination

reveals how threatening this kind of cross-racial organizing was to the status quo. The Rainbow Coalition set a model for later attempts to build solidarity across race without erasing the specific realities of Black oppression.

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10. Black Lives Matter and the Ongoing Struggle

Finally, I chose **Black Lives Matter (BLM)** because it links the long history we studied to my own lifetime. According to the movement's own history, three Black women organizers Alicia Garza, Patrisse Cullors, and Opal Tometi created #BlackLivesMatter in 2013 after the acquittal of George Zimmerman in the killing of Trayvon Martin. The movement grew even larger after the police killings of Michael Brown in Ferguson and, especially, George Floyd in 2020.

Reports show that the 2020 protests, which spread to thousands of cities in the U.S. and around the world, may have involved between 15 and 26 million participants, making BLM one of the largest protest movements in American history. Images and news stories from that summer show both massive peaceful marches and harsh police crackdowns. Black Lives Matter matters to African-American history because it proves that, even after civil rights laws, systemic racism and police violence are still being challenged by new generations using social media, decentralized leadership, and global solidarity.

Conclusion

Putting these ten examples together from Mansa Musa to Black Lives Matter. I see African-American history as a story of constant reinvention. It begins in powerful African kingdoms, is shattered by the Middle Passage, but refuses to be reduced to slavery. Individuals like Equiano, Walker, and Grimké used

words and faith to attack slavery's moral foundations. Mass movements like abolitionism and the civil rights struggle turned those ideas into action, while cultural movements like the Harlem Renaissance insisted on Black creativity and pride. The Rainbow Coalition and Black Lives Matter show that the fight for justice is still evolving, connecting race, class, gender, and global politics.

For me, the most important lesson from this course is that African-American history is not just about suffering; it is about agency. At every stage, Black people and their allies thought, organized, created art, and imagined better futures. That tradition continues today, and it challenges me to think about what role I will play in the story.

CITATIONS

Textbook & Reader (American Yawp)

- *Locke, Joseph, and Ben Wright, eds. The American Yawp, Vol. 1 (to 1877) and Vol. 2 (since 1877). Stanford University Press / Online open text. Especially Chs. 3 "British North America," 4 "Colonial Society," 10 "Religion and Reform," 11 "The Cotton Revolution," 22 "The New Era," 26 "The Affluent Society," and 27 "The Sixties*
- *The American Yawp Reader, selections: Olaudah Equiano, "Olaudah Equiano Describes the Middle Passage" (1789); David Walker, Appeal to the Colored Citizens of the World (1829); Angelina Grimké, "Appeal to the Christian Women of the South" (1836); William Lloyd Garrison, "Introduces The Liberator" (1831); Alain Locke, "The New Negro" (1925); "Selma Marchers" and other civil rights images.*
- *"Mansa Musa." Encyclopaedia Britannica and related essays on his hajj and the Mali Empire's wealth and learning.*

- *“Harlem Renaissance.” National Museum of African American History and Culture; Poetry Foundation overview of the Harlem Renaissance.*
- *“Rainbow Coalition (Fred Hampton).” and related pieces on the Young Lords and Young Patriots*
- *“Black Lives Matter: Our History” and “About Black Lives Matter.” Official Black Lives Matter website; background on the 2020 protests.*
- “The Middle Passage: A Brutal Slave-Trade Supply Chain.” (YouTube educational video).youtube.com+1
- *The Abolitionists* (PBS *American Experience*), especially segments on William Lloyd Garrison and Frederick Douglass.youtube.com+1
- “Angelina Grimké – Abolitionist” .youtube.com+1